

Session 23: The Reunion of Jacob and Esau

Key Takeaways

- After his wrestling match with God, Yaaqov, the wounded servant, sacrifices himself on behalf of everything he holds dear.
- Esau's reaction to Yaaqov's return, running to him and embracing him, points forward to Jesus' parable of the loving father embracing his prodigal son.
- Yaaqov recognizes the image of God in Esau's face, moving him to love his brother the way he would love God.

Yaaqov Reconciles With Esau and Offers Up His Life

¹ **And Yaaqov lifted his eyes and saw** ,
and behold, **Esau was coming**,
and with him were four hundred men,

and he divided the **children**
by **Leah, and by Rakhel, and by the two servants** .

² And he placed **the servants and their children first**,
and Leah and **her children afterwards**,
and **Rakhel and Joseph afterwards**.

³ And he himself passed on **before the face of them**
and **he bowed down** to the ground seven times,
until he came near to his brother.

⁴ **And Esau ran to meet him**
and he embraced him and fell on his neck and kissed him,
and they wept.

⁵ **And he [Esau] lifted his eyes and saw** **the women and the children** ,
and he said,
“ **Who are these with you** ?”
And he said,
“The **children** with whom **God has favored (חנן) your servant.**”

⁶ And **the servants came near with their children** , and they bowed down.

⁷ And **Leah likewise came near with her children** , and they bowed down;
and **afterwards Joseph and Rakhel came near** , and they bowed down.

⁸ And he said,

“ **What is it to you** , all this **camp (מחנה)** that I have encountered?”

And he said,

“**To find favor (חן) in the eyes of my lord.**”

⁹ And Esau said,

“ **I have much, my brother** ;

let what you have belong to you.”

¹⁰ And Yaaqov said,

“No, please, **if now I have found favor (חן) in your eyes**,
then **take my offering (מנחה)** from my hand,
for this reason:

I have seen your face as one sees the face of God ,

and you have accepted me.

¹¹ Please **take my blessing** which has been brought to you,
because **God has shown favor (חנן) to me**,
and because I have everything .”

And he urged him,
and **he took it**.

Genesis 33:1-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The scene progresses in two parallel panels that create a fascinating comparison and contrast between the two brothers.

- Genesis 33:1-4 focuses on Yaaqov's perception (33:1), his response (33:1b-3) of placing the family members in order of favor, and then placing himself in front of them all as he bows down to his brother. This is a surprise shift from the previous day's plan, where he places all the wives and children up front, even though he knew their lives were at risk. This move to the front shows that Yaaqov has undergone a deep character transformation.
- The surprising twist (33:4) is that Esau runs to be reconciled with his brother, showing affection and love. The inner contrast is between Yaaqov's self-preservation scheme and Esau's generous love.
- Genesis 33:5-8 unfolds with a parallel progression, this time opening with Esau's perception (33:5) and his response of astonishment at how many people and animals there are (33:5b-8).

- Notice how Genesis 33:5b-8 contains the progressive list of wives and children at the center, flanked by two short dialogues between the brothers that portray the family as an expression of God's "favor" that Yaaqov uses to gain "favor" in the eyes of his brother.

The middle sub-unit in Genesis 33:9-11 shows Yaaqov back in his native mode of transactional self-preservation as he attempts to give an "offering" to his brother. However, the concentric design of this unit makes a more subtle point. Notice how Yaaqov calls the animals an offering (מנחה) in 33:10, but then in the matching line he asks his brother to "take" (לקח) "the blessing" (ברכה). Yaaqov's purpose becomes clear; this "gift" is his attempt to undo his actions from chapter 27, where he took (לקח) the blessing (ברכה) from this brother (Gen. 27:36).

This climactic scene sheds light on the previous narrative of Yaaqov at the Jabbok, where he wrestled with the "God-man," received a blessing, and "saw the face of God." Now, faced with his brother from whom he stole the blessing, we see that Yaaqov's struggle with his brother over the blessing is one and the same as his struggle with God to gain the blessing. At the Jabbok, Yaaqov was wounded and humbled, and yet received the blessing after all. So now Yaaqov gives up his struggle to usurp his brother, and he "gives up" the blessing, only to receive it in a new and more powerful way.

Yaaqov, Ever the Schemer

¹² And he said,

"**Let us journey** (נסע) and let us go,
and I will go before you."

¹³ And he said to him,

"**My lord** knows that the **children** are tender
and **the flocks and herds** which are nursing are with me,
and should they drive them one day, all the flocks will die.

¹⁴ Please let **my lord** pass on before **his servant**,

and I will proceed at my leisure,
according to the pace of the **cattle** that are before me
and according to the pace of the **children**,
until I come to my lord at **Seir**."

¹⁵ And Esau said,

"Please let me leave with you some of the people who are with me."

And he said,

"What need is there?

Let me find favor in the eyes of my lord."

¹⁶ And Esau returned that day on his way to **Seir**.

17 **And Yaaqov journeyed** (נסע) to **Sukkoth** [= “Booths”]
and he built for himself a house
and he made **booths** for his livestock;
therefore the name of the place is called **Sukkoth**.

Genesis 33:1-17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Here we see Yaaqov's evasive and scheming nature re-emerge. While he clearly wants to be reconciled to his brother, we now wonder about his ultimate motives. Perhaps what he really wants is simply to live in the land of his birth and ancestors, and making peace with Esau is a necessary step. Every response of Yaaqov sounds like a lame excuse. Esau wants to live together, but Yaaqov lets the "weakness" of the flocks and children pose the obstacle (much like he placed the animals and children in front of himself as a human shield in [chapter 32](#)).

At the culmination of his excuses, Yaaqov simply lies outright and says he will follow Esau to Seir. He has no intention of doing this, and his actions tell the real story. As soon as Yaaqov and Esau are reunited, Yaaqov tries to get his brother out of his hair and territory. Yaaqov is on a mission to get back into the land and be near his father.

Reflection Question

What does it mean when Yaaqov says to Esau, “I have seen your face as one sees the face of God”? Where else do we see this theme in the Bible?